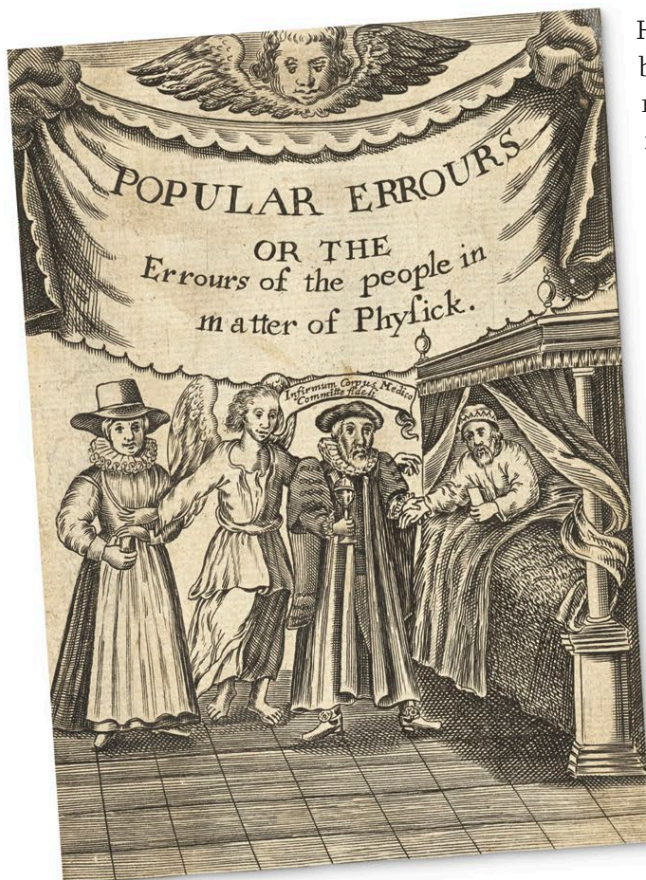


CUNNING FOLK

popular practices



▲ Medicine over magic

As science advanced during the Renaissance, cunning folk were increasingly seen as dangerous quacks. This title page from a 1651 publication shows a patient being treated by a doctor while an angel bars a cunning woman from participating.

Historically, magic has often been divided into high, learned magic, and low, popular or folk magic, and this distinction held true between the 1400s and 1600s. Popular magic featured herbs and animals said to have special powers; traditional beliefs; and protective charms. It overlapped with folk healing and good witchcraft, as well as with some higher learned magic.

Central to popular magic were its practitioners, often called cunning folk. They were well-known members of local communities, and their low-key magic helped ordinary people with everyday problems, such as attracting a wife, banishing warts, improving crops, or gaining protection

from malign witchcraft.

Cunning folks' skills embraced herbal medicine and midwifery, and some practices even borrowed from aspects of Christianity: for example, a spell linked to the herb vervain stated: "Hallowed be thou Vervain, as thou growest on the ground / For in the mount of Calvary there thou was first found." Popular magic was vital across Europe, and practitioners included the *klok gumma* (Sweden), the visionary *táltos* (Hungary), and the *benandanti* (Italy).

Persecution and problems

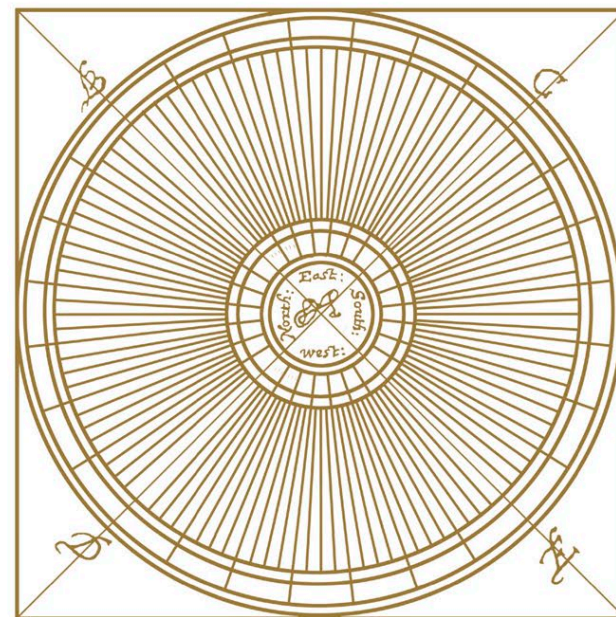
Many Renaissance folk practices were continuations from medieval times. However, in the 1500s spiritual dabblings were increasingly considered a threat to authority—that of the state and the

Church—and legislation was sought to control them. What was perceived as harmful witchcraft was obviously a prime target, and indeed some cunning folk did follow darker arts, but benign practices could also be condemned. Nevertheless, despite fluctuating threats during the 1500s, the practices of cunning folk seemed to flourish in many ways.

This era brought with it some terrible events across the globe, from European plague pandemics in the 1500s and 1600s, to catastrophic earthquakes and floods—such as the Netherlands' St. Felix's Flood in 1530—as well as famine among 17th-century North American settlers. In addition, life was brutally hard for ordinary people. It is likely that popular magic brought much-needed solace to the poorest in society.

Magic circles

The art of using circles in ritual magic was a tool employed by some cunning folk, as well as more learned magic practitioners. The magic circle was a symbol of protection and of the summoning of spirits, and was often drawn protectively around those performing magic. Also called "conjuring circles," magic circles were often physically drawn on the ground.



► The seal of secrets

Designed to harness magical forces, this circle appears in the practice book of a 17th-century cunning man; it is said to represent "the seal of the secrets of all the world."